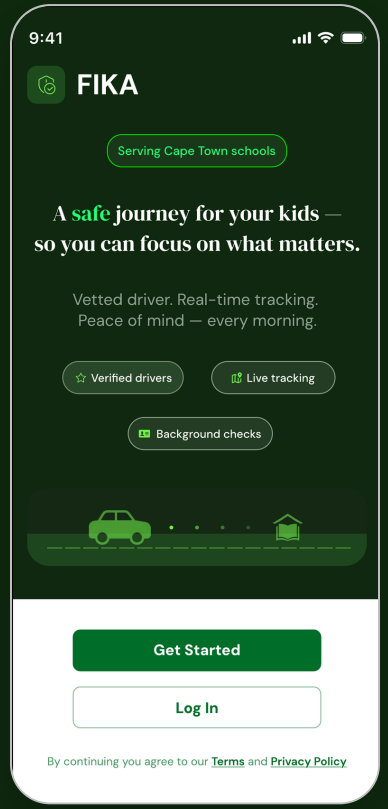
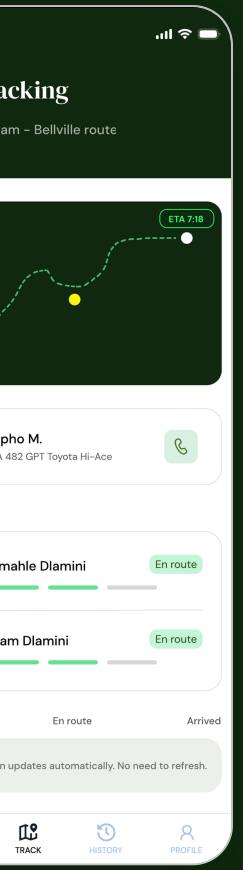
FIKA

Did my child arrive?

A child-only school transport app for Cape Town, with one interface for parents and one for drivers.

Chris Lufuilu · UX/UI Designer
Case study · May to August 2026





THE CONTEXT

In Cape Town, parents find school drivers through word of mouth. It works, but it has no accountability layer.

- Parents already use private school transport, but trust travels through neighbours and friends.
- It does not scale, and nobody has proof when something goes wrong.
- FIKA formalises that trust: vetted, employed drivers in company-owned, GPS-tracked vehicles.

FIKA

Swahili. *To arrive.*

Swahili is my home language. The name was chosen on purpose: the whole product exists to answer one question a parent asks every school morning.

“Did my child arrive?”

Chris Lufuilu
UX/UI Designer

THE CONCEPT

A company, not a gig platform.

Parents register, add their children, choose a school area and are assigned to a route. FIKA approves the application, assigns a driver, and parents pay a monthly fee.

Employed, vetted drivers

Every driver completes a driving assessment and a full background check before being assigned a route, and works under a legal employment contract.

Company-owned vehicles

Vehicles return to the company yard once every child is dropped off. Drivers do not take them home.

GPS-tracked at all times

Parents see the journey live. The company monitors route adherence. Any deviation is recorded, and drivers know this as a condition of employment.

The same data that reassures a parent is the data that clears a driver of a false accusation.

Chris Lufuilu
UX/UI Designer

THE OBJECTIVE

Design a dual-interface app where one set of timestamped data reassures parents and protects drivers.

Parents

Visibility. Screens that feel calm, clear and in control.

Drivers

Proof. Screens that feel organised, fast and protected.

One data source

The parent sees the car move; the driver generates that movement.

Chris Lufuilu
UX/UI Designer

1. EMPATHISE | 2. CONCEPTUALISE | 3. DESIGN

Understanding two people on opposite sides of the same gap.

1. EMPATHISE 2 3

Parents were anxious. Drivers were unprotected.



PARENT · NOMSA

It is 7:45. Her phone is off. Amahle (9) walked with a neighbour's child; Liam (14) took the minibus taxi alone.

"I just need to know they got there."



DRIVER · SIPHO

A mother accused him of not taking her son to school. For three hours he had nothing to show her.

"I've been doing this job properly and now they're blaming me."

Both describe the same gap from opposite sides.

Chris Lufuilu
UX/UI Designer

1. EMPATHISE 2 3

The first trip is the hardest.

THE MOMENT

When a parent puts their child in the car for the first time and it drives away, they do not feel relief or trust. Those come later. What they feel is **controlled anxiety**.

How does FIKA convert first-time anxiety into earned trust, one trip at a time?

THE ANSWER: VISIBILITY

Every pickup confirmation, every arrived notification and every timestamped drop-off turns one moment of anxiety into relief.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Cape Town parents of primary and high school learners struggle to trust their children's safety travelling to and from school, because there is no affordable, child-only, trustworthy transport solution that gives them real visibility into whether their child arrived safely.

Chris Lufuilu
UX/UI Designer

1. EMPATHISE 2 3

Empathy maps: two people, one gap.

PARENT · A WORKING CAPE TOWN PARENT

SAYS
"I can't always be there to fetch them"

"I just need to know they got there"

THINKS
What if the driver is not who he says he is

What if my child doesn't get on the car

DOES
Calls the child repeatedly until they confirm arrival

Asks a neighbour or relative to watch out

FEELS
Chronic low-level anxiety every school morning

Guilt when they cannot be present

DRIVER · A VETTED FIKA DRIVER

SAYS
"The parent never told me she wasn't coming today"

"I've been doing this job properly and now they're blaming me"

THINKS
I need proof that I did my job correctly

If I lose this job I lose my income

DOES
Calls the parent when a child doesn't come out

Takes personal notes or screenshots to protect himself

FEELS
Unprotected when accusations come without evidence

Proud when the route runs smoothly

The parent needs visibility to feel safe. The driver needs records to feel protected. The same data solves both.

Chris Lufuilu
UX/UI Designer

1. EMPATHISE 2 3

Six cognitive biases shaped the design.

Familiarity

Parents expect the Uber and Bolt model: map, moving dot, ETA.

→ Tracking must feel instantly familiar.

Paradox of choice

An anxious parent abandons long forms.

→ Onboarding in small, committed steps.

Anchoring

The first number sets the sense of value.

→ Price appears late, after trust is built.

Loss aversion

Parents pay to avoid loss, not for convenience.

→ Messaging leads with what they no longer worry about.

Von Restorff

If every child looks identical, nothing stands out.

→ Medical notes and special instructions look distinct.

Peak-end rule

Parents remember the peak moment and the last.

→ The arrived notification must feel warm and immediate.

1. EMPATHISE 2 3

I started with two in-depth interviews.



Nomsa D., 34

Admin clerk, Bellville · single income
Daughter Grade 4, son Grade 8 · Android user

8 findings



Sipho M., 29

School driver, Brackenfell · 2 years
6 children across 3 schools · own car

13 findings

- Why interviews: this is a product about emotion, trust and safety. Numbers cannot capture why a parent is anxious or why a driver feels unprotected.
- Format: one-on-one and conversational, scenario-based, no scripts. Follow the emotion and ask why.
- Two conversations, not a large study, so I treated the 21 findings as signals to design from, not statistics.

> It would make me feel like a better mother. Like I did something right for my children even though I cannot be there with them.



Nomsa D., research participant

PARENT FINDINGS

What Nomsa taught me

- **Word of mouth cannot cross neighbourhoods.** A trusted driver in Parow cannot help a parent in Bellville.
- **Formal accountability matters.** A neighbour offering transport is not a company offering transport.
- **One notification would change her morning.** Not a fancy feature; just a message that says they are there.
- **FIKA is not selling transport.** It is selling the feeling of being a good parent despite impossible circumstances.

1. EMPATHISE 2 3

The Kavelo incident: three hours with nothing to show.

1

The drop-off

Sipho drops Kavelo at school and watches him walk through the gate.

2

The call

That afternoon his mother calls: the school says Kavelo was never in class.

3

The accusation

She accuses Sipho of not taking him to school.

4

Three hours

Sipho has no timestamp and no record. His word against a scared mother's fear.

5

The truth

Kavelo left through a hole in the fence at break. His mother apologised. The doubt stayed.



"I just want to do it properly. With the right tools. So that everyone, the parents, the children, me, feels safe and respected." Sipho M.

Two personas, built from the interviews.



PARENT PERSONA

Nomsa D., 34

Admin clerk · Bellville · Android user · single income

5:30	2	7:00	12:30
DAY STARTS	CHILDREN	LEAVES FOR WORK	FIRST PHONE CHECK

GOALS

- Know both children arrived, without calling and waiting
- Feel like a responsible mother, even when she can't be there

FRUSTRATIONS

- Phone off at her desk, not knowing if they got there
- Informal drivers: no contract, no insurance, no recourse

KEY DESIGN INSIGHT

Nomsa is not paying for transport. She is paying to feel like a good mother despite impossible circumstances.



DRIVER PERSONA

Sipho M., 29

Informal school driver · Brackenfell · 2 years

5:45	6	3	3 sec
DAY STARTS	CHILDREN	SCHOOLS	MAX SCREEN TIME

GOALS

- A verifiable record of every drop-off he can point to
- Absence alerts before he leaves, not after the trip

FRUSTRATIONS

- Accused without evidence, with no way to defend himself
- Parents who know a child is absent but stay silent

KEY DESIGN INSIGHT

Sipho does not resist being tracked, he wants it. Every interaction must be completable in under three seconds.

1. EMPATHISE | **2. CONCEPTUALISE** | 3. DESIGN

Turning 21 findings into five insights and a design direction.

1 **2. CONCEPTUALISE** 3

Twenty-one findings needed a strategy.

1

Capture

21 findings laid out flat: 8 from the parent, 13 from the driver.

2

Cluster

Five themes: trust, communication, safety, efficiency, emotional value.

3

Insights

Five insights, each reframed as a design principle.

4

How might we

Fifteen questions: surface, structural and deep for every insight.

Then I built two personas, Nomsa and Sipho, and mapped both current-state journeys.

1 2. CONCEPTUALISE 3

Affinity map: five clusters.

1

Trust and accountability

Parent 2, 4, 6 · Driver 2, 4, 7, 11

Trust is built through structure, visibility and formal accountability on both sides.

2

Communication breakdown

Parent 1, 5, 7 · Driver 1, 9

Every pain point traces back to a communication gap. The app closes it automatically.

3

Safety and protection

Parent 3, 6, 8 · Driver 3, 7, 12, 13

For parents safety is emotional. For drivers it is legal. The app serves both.

4

Operational efficiency

Driver 5, 6, 8, 9, 10

The driver interface is a safety-critical tool. Efficiency protects children.

5

Emotional value

Parent 7, 8 · Driver 4, 11

Both users need to feel something, not just use the app.

Journey maps: where FIKA steps in.



NOMSA · PARENT

TODAY, BEFORE FIKA

5:30–6:00	6:00–6:50	6:50–7:00	7:00–7:15	7:15–lunch	Lunch
Morning prep	**Getting kids ready**	**Sending them off**	**Commute**	**At work, phone off**	**First confirmation**
Tired, focused	Stressed, rushing	Anxious, guilty	Worried, helpless	Peak anxiety	Relief only if they answer

WITH FIKA · INTENDED FEELING

Outside FIKA's scope	Outside FIKA's scope	**Reassured** Pickup notification	**In control** Live tracking	**Relieved** Arrived notification	**Calm** Check-in becomes unnecessary



SIPHO · DRIVER

Night before	5:45	6:00–7:00	7:00–7:30	7:15–7:45	7:45+
Plans the route	**Morning prep**	**Pickups**	**Driving to schools**	**Drop-offs**	**After drop-off**
Carrying it alone	Uncertain	Frustrated, disrespected	Stressed, responsible	Partly relieved	Unprotected
Prepared Auto-loaded manifest	**Informed** Absences already in manifest	**Respected** Timestamp at every pickup	**Focused** Built-in GPS navigation	**Settled** GPS-triggered confirmation	**Protected** Timestamped trip records

Intended feelings are design goals, not tested results.

1 **2. CONCEPTUALISE** 3

Five insights became the design brief.

INSIGHT	HOW MIGHT WE…
1 **Trust is infrastructure**	How might we create a product that makes a parent feel safer trusting a vetted company than trusting a neighbour she has known for years?
2 **The app is the communication layer**	How might we remove human memory entirely from the communication chain between parent and driver?
3 **Safety has two currencies**	How might we design an app where every interaction serves both the parent's emotional need and the driver's legal need at once?
4 **The driver interface is safety-critical**	How might we design a driver interface where the app thinks ahead so the driver never has to? Target: a confirmation screen the driver completes in 3 seconds or less, because children are in the car.
5 **FIKA sells relief, not transport**	How might we make a parent feel like a good parent every school morning, whether or not she can be there?

1 **2. CONCEPTUALISE** 3

The problem, sharpened.

Cape Town parents of primary and high school learners struggle to trust their children's safety travelling to and from school, because there is no affordable, child-only, trustworthy transport solution that gives them real visibility into whether their child arrived safely.

The informal system also creates:

No assurance for drivers

Nothing protects a driver who did the job correctly.

No protection from fear

Parents act out of fear or emotion with no facts to check.

No communication channel

Nothing structured exists when something unexpected happens.

A road-safety risk

Drivers navigate unfamiliar routes with children in the car.

1. EMPATHISE | 2. CONCEPTUALISE | **3. DESIGN**

Designing for two users with one live source of truth.

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

Information architecture: two apps, one data source.

PARENT APP · 5 SECTIONS

1. **Onboarding**
   Register, add children, select area, await approval
2. **Home dashboard**
   Live trip status, driver details, absence shortcut
3. **Tracking**
   Live map, route progress, ETA
4. **My children**
   Profiles, schedules, report absence
5. **Account**
   Payments, settings, complaints

Live trip data
timestamps · location · absences

DRIVER APP · 4 SECTIONS

1. **Home: shift dashboard**
   Profile, start shift, shift summary
2. **Today's manifest**
   Who is coming, who is absent, in route order
3. **Active route**
   GPS navigation, pickup and drop-off confirmations
4. **Reports**
   Incident reports, complaints, timestamped trip history

The core IA insight: the parent's Tracking screen and the driver's Active route screen run on the same live data. One data source, two interfaces, two users served at once.

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

Every screen had to earn its place.

1

Calm for parents, fast for drivers

Every feature that did not serve those feelings was cut.

2

The same data, two jobs

A confirmation tap is a notification for the parent and a legal timestamp for the driver.

3

GPS does the organising

The driver only confirms; the app surfaces the right children.

4

Price comes late

It appears after vetting and tracking have built trust.

5

Emergency breaks the brand

Red, no forms, one tap to call. See the next slide.

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

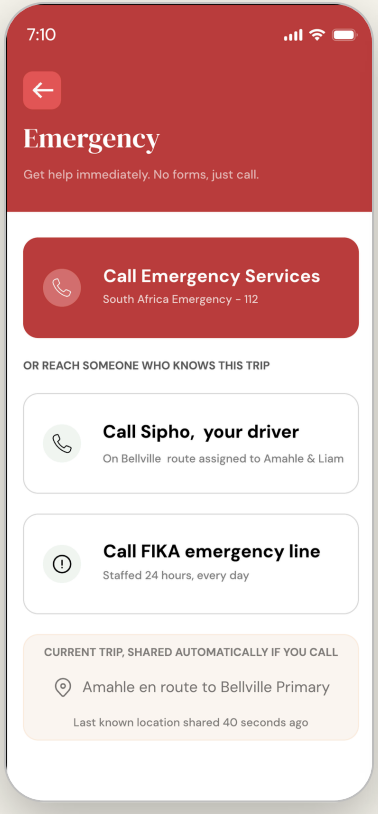
When something goes wrong, FIKA drops its brand.

Emergency is the one place the calm green gives way to red. There is nothing to fill in: help is one tap away, for both users.

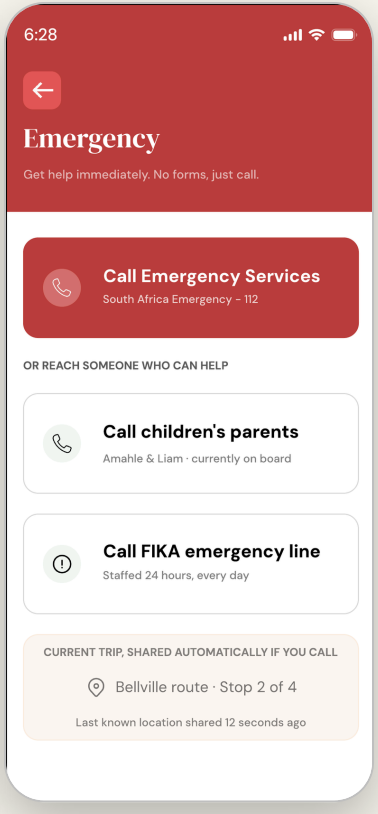
Three ways to get help
Emergency services (112), the person who knows the trip, or the FIKA line, staffed 24 hours.

The trip travels with the call
The current trip and last known location are shared automatically if the user calls.

Same pattern, two users
The parent reaches the driver. The driver reaches the children's parents.



Parent
Reach the driver or FIKA



Driver
Reach the parents or FIKA

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

A design system built on meaning.

Forest
#0F2A0F · Headers

Action green
#03702B · Primary buttons

Confirmed
#DDEADD · Tag fill

Absent
#F2C6C6 · Tag fill

Emergency
#BC3E3C · Red mode

Accent
#2AFF78 · Highlights

Aa
DM Serif Display
Headlines: warm, human

Aa
DM Sans
All UI text: clear, quick to read

Confirmed Absent Awaiting

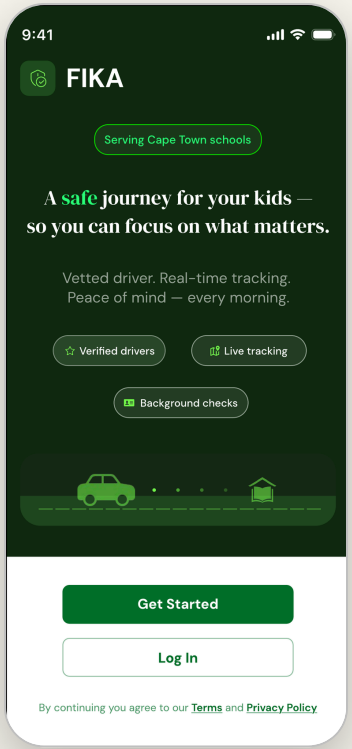
Start route

60-30-10: neutral surfaces, forest green structure, and one action colour so the primary button is never in doubt.

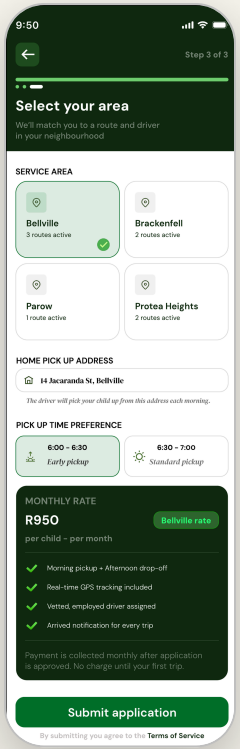
Colour = status. Green is confirmed, red is absent, grey is awaiting. Red is also reserved for emergencies.

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

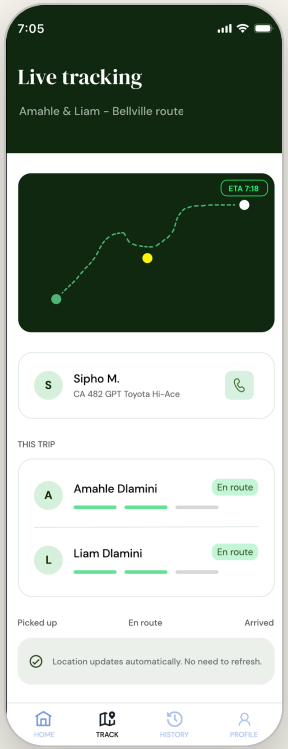
Parent flow: from anxious to relieved.



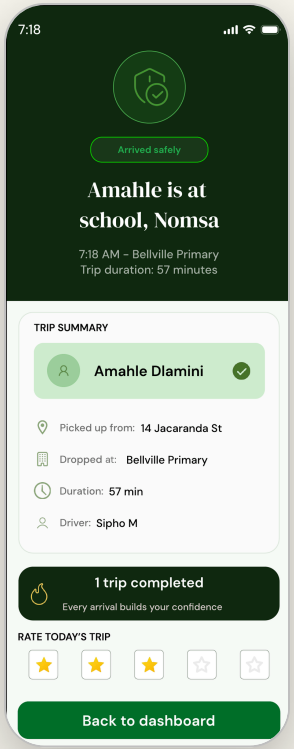
1 Welcome
Trust before sign-up



2 Select area
Price appears late



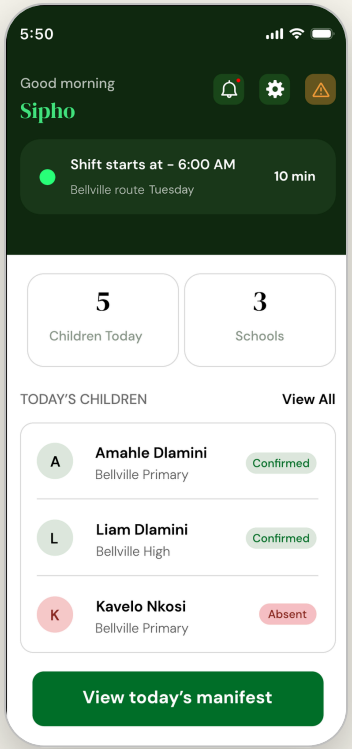
3 Live tracking
Watch the car move



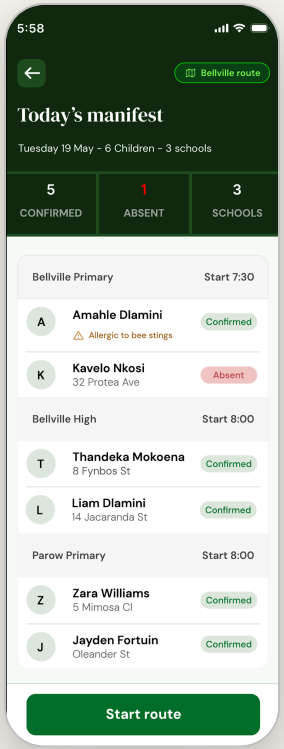
4 Arrived safely
The moment she exhales

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

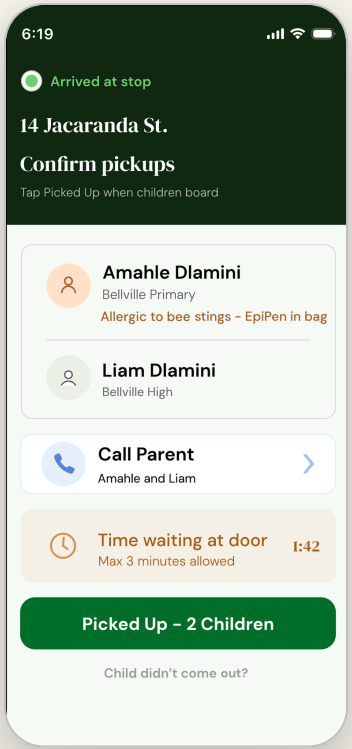
Driver flow: organised, fast, protected.



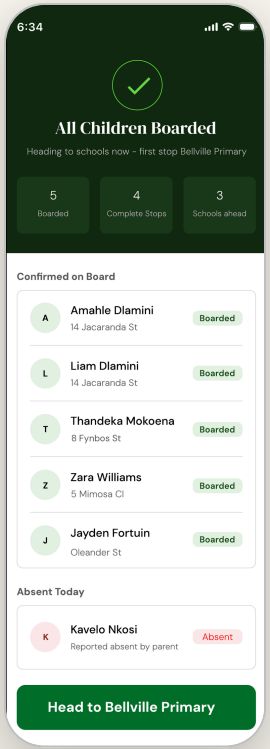
1 Shift dashboard
Who and where today



2 Today's manifest
Absences flagged early



3 Arrive at house
Allergy stands out



4 All children boarded
Timestamps saved

1 2 **3. DESIGN**

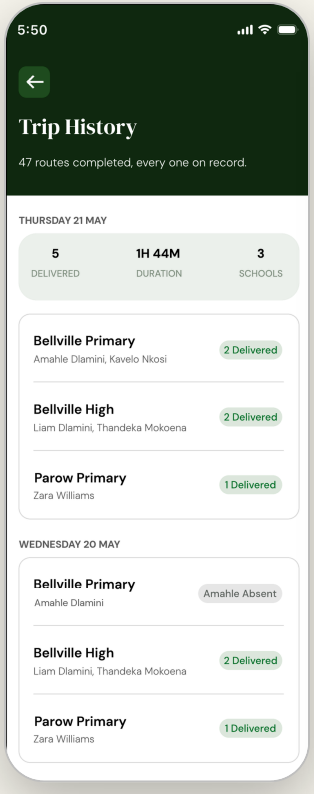
If Kavelo happened again, Sipho would have proof.

THEN

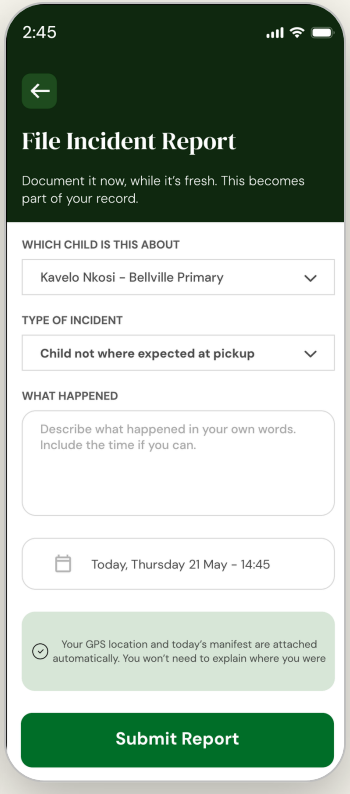
Three hours. No timestamp, no record. His word against a scared mother's fear.

WITH FIKA

Every trip stays on record. The incident report attaches his GPS location and the day's manifest automatically, so he never has to explain where he was.



Trip history
Every trip on record



File incident report
Evidence attached automatically

WHAT I PROVED, AND WHAT'S NEXT

Both interfaces designed end to end, then honestly evaluated.

- Designed parent and driver flows from onboarding and live tracking to timestamped trip records.
- Self-evaluated every screen against Nielsen's heuristics and the four Stage 1 test questions. This was a self-evaluation, not user testing.
- Fixed what it found: a hardcoded parent name, two disconnected timers, a dead button, inconsistent greens.
- Next: usability testing with real parents and drivers against the four Stage 1 questions, including whether a driver can complete a route with no more than three seconds on the screen per stop.

2
interfaces

21
research findings

5
insights

FIKA

Thank you

Chris Lufuilu · UX/UI Designer

behance.net/chrislufuilu

linkedin.com/in/chris-l-036564230

chrislufuilu723@gmail.com